Centering Civic Engagement with Open Scholarship: The Revolutionary City as a Model for Fostering Public Use of Digital Cultural Heritage

Nelson, David Ragnar
dnelson@amphilsoc.org
American Philosophical Society, United States of America

Miller, Bayard L.
bmiller@amphilsoc.org
American Philosophical Society, United States of America

Mass digitization has made great strides in making archival holdings more available, but has this made these documents more usable to the general public? As Dorothy Berry (2024) has argued, archival conventions for metadata and item description do not always guide nonspecialist audiences to the information they seek, particularly when the information concerns minoritized groups. Constructing an online exhibition or digital site is a frequent solution to this problem, but it does not guarantee that audiences will be able to meaningfully engage with the holdings. On the other hand, as Melissa Terras (2022b) among others has noted, the advent of handwritten text recognition (HTR) has the possibility to massively increase access to handwritten sources in libraries and archives. At the same time, full-text search neither provides a solution to the problem of fostering public engagement with archival holdings, nor does it undo the harm caused by generations of noninclusive archival practices. Additionally, while some literature acknowledges the incorporation of HTR into project and digitization workflows (Pinche 2024), much of the literature on HTR has focused on providing it for the use of individual historians (Terras 2022a; Humphries et al 2024) and does not address how these tools can incorporate public audiences.

This paper will propose a new model for increasing access to and engagement with archival holdings. We argue enhanced access to cultural heritage rests upon three central pillars: digitization, transcription, and community-informed digital outreach and scholarship. In particular, this approach encourages engagement not only with the historical documents themselves, but also with the digital tools used in their online presentation. This method unites two parallel strands of public engagement. On the one side, the project engages public audiences to produce training data for HTR models and to correct the output of these models (Fritz et al 2021). On the other, a team of education outreach specialists conducts educator workshops and community-based events to draw up plans for educational resources and public content based on the holdings. Through this, we hope to extend the activities of the project beyond the traditional confines of the project team and engage users who can become part of the "epistemic culture" of the project and contribute to its further development and use (Malazita et al 2020). These approaches unite in a public-facing web portal which displays the digitized archival holdings, the transcriptions, and digital scholarship drawn from community outreach.

As the United States approaches the 250th anniversary of its founding in 2026, cultural institutions are seeking meaningful ways to engage public audiences in critical reflection on the nation's history. *The Revolutionary City*, a collaborative effort spearheaded by six Philadelphia-based collecting institutions, provides one such framework. The project is a hybrid digital library and scholarly publishing venue that seeks to unite all manuscript material concerning Philadelphia during the Revolutionary War (1774-1783) (Punzalan 2014). The project's team takes seriously the need for collecting institutions to contribute to promoting engagement with history (Owens / Johnston 2022). Currently, it aggregates material from four different repositories, provides educational resources, and presents digital scholarship for both experts and the general public.

A central aspect of the project is a participatory ethos in which the main audience for the project is also co-constitutive in its development. Numerous previous attempts at promoting engagement with the history of the United States suggested putting documents on the web is sufficient to "democratize" history or encourage use (VandeCreek 2007; Abbott 2012). We contend, however, that audiences must also be engaged in creating and using the material. The initial pilot of the project featured a stakeholder group of prominent historians of early America, secondary school teachers, archivists, as well as a historical reenactor and a representative of the Delaware Tribe of Indians. As the project has expanded, it has held workshops

to help educators improve and use the project's resources and has solicited content from leading historians, with an eye towards engaging educators who work with the diverse population of Philadelphia public schools. Additionally, the American Philosophical Society will stage an exhibition in its museum in 2025 to highlight material and narratives in the portal, helping to promote use of the digital portal's resources among the general public.

To encourage reuse and participation, the project is committed to open scholarship. All digitized manuscripts will be available for download via an open access policy and will also be retrievable via IIIF manifest. All educational materials will also be available for download and use via an open access policy. Additionally, the project integrates several open source technologies. The portal itself uses Islandora, a Drupal-based digital repository, and digital content is being prepared with several open source technologies, including D3.js for interactive visualizations and TimelineJS and StorymapJS for narrative content.

The project also uses the open source software programs kraken and eScriptorium (Kiessling et al 2019) to generate transcriptions of the documents. This process also seeks transparency, public participation, and community use. At a series of transcription workshops and transcribathons, public audiences have had the chance to try these handwritten text recognition (HTR) tools, generate training data to improve the models, and provide feedback on the utility of the models. All models and training data are released on Zenodo and registered the data on HTR-United, a catalog for publicly available HTR training data (Chagué / Clérice 2023), following best practices for model distribution (Kherroubi Garcia et al 2025).

The project team is currently considering how best to integrate the transcriptions into the portal. As there will not be sufficient time or resources to correct all automatically generated transcriptions, they will have to be marked with a disclaimer and a means to meaningfully suggest corrections. The current integration of these technologies does not provide a straightforward way to crowdsource these corrections (e.g. in a Wiki-style document that anyone can edit). Additionally, as the project was spearheaded by independent research libraries, it does not have as ready access to conventional sources of labor that are available for digital humanities projects run by universities (e.g. undergraduate student workers). But the project team is actively cultivating a team of volunteers and paid student interns when resources allow that could be used to make corrections and edits as problems are discovered. As the project serves as an authoritative source of historical documents and information, the project team is deeply concerned about irresponsibly providing bad machine-generated transcriptions. This would go against the project's key goals of fostering critical reflection and civic dialog about the history of the United States and could contribute to the spread of misinformation. For this reason, transcriptions may only be provided on demand or when resources allow for correction. By providing public access to both the models and the training data, the project seeks to promote active participation by its users in evaluating and improving these transcriptions.

As the project prepares to foster the portal and its content through July 2026 and beyond, the current work provides a model for: the integration of manuscript material into digital resources from under-resourced institutions, community-engaged efforts at developing HTR technologies, and the creation of additional interpretive content about these materials by those closest to the audiences the project hopes to reach. The existing material can serve as a model that new partners can use to write and contribute their own material, providing a sustainable framework for long-term growth of the portal and continued engagement. Additionally, as the project's audiences grow, the team's contribution model where any writing or web content that references materials in the portal can be hosted on the portal provides a means for direct community contribution. In doing this, the project models the type of participatory reflection on history that it seeks to enact.

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